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The Invention of *Wa* and the Transformation of the Image of Prince Shotoku in Modern Japan

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I have long doubted the existence of Japanese collectivism as a historically transcendent cultural trait. Also, I have a long-standing personal interest in Prince Shotoku and his image in Japanese society. The purpose of this paper is to reconsider the changing historical meaning of the spirit of *wa* (harmony) and Shotoku's image together in relation to their symbolic function in the national integration of modern Japan.

Today *wa* is a ubiquitous signifier of Japanese collectivism. The character often appears on decorative scrolls and is explicitly cited in the management policies of many companies (see fig. 1). Anyone reading the word will recall the "Seventeen-Article Constitution" laid down by Prince Shotoku (572-621), which, it is believed, evokes *wa* as a guiding principle. Yet despite these historical connotations, the spirit of *wa* associated with the name of Prince Shotoku may in fact be a modern invention.

As developed by Eric Hobsbawm, the "invention of tradition" is closely related to the formation of modern nation-states.¹ I will interpret the invention of *wa* as a process through which members of the ruling class revised and reorganized part of Japan's ancient history into new symbols at a time when they faced the challenge of integrating the nation and inculcating a national consciousness. This paper proposes to think through the invention of tradition in modern Japan by viewing *wa* and the changing image of Prince Shotoku through the lens of Hobsbawm's work.

The question of the modern nation-state has become a controversial issue recently, since the nation-state itself is in crisis. Following Benedict Anderson's *Imagined Communities*,² I will approach the nation-state from a cultural viewpoint and

¹ Eric J. Hobsbawm and Terence O. Ranger, eds., *The Invention of Tradition* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1983).

² Benedict R. Anderson, *Imagined Communities* (London: Verso, 1991).

will argue that modernization always involves the invention of new traditions to stabilize itself. Modernization and the invention of tradition proceed together in a nested relationship. There are many examples of this process in modern Japan's political development—for example, the image of the Meiji emperor and the modern imperial ideology that grew from it are invented traditions. I would also argue that, on a more quotidian level, *shichi-go-san* (the ritual celebrating children's reaching the age of seven, five, and three), the Shinto marriage ceremony, and indeed state Shinto itself are traditions that were invented after the beginning of the Meiji era.

First of all, let me cite some current examples of the spirit of *wa*. Takagiwa Hiroo variously describes *wa* as "a traditional practice of mutual assistance embedded in everyday life"; "freedom and equality in a community"; "a decision by consensus"; and "a nonidealistic and emotional tie."³ These descriptions, I believe, are very close to what most Japanese think about *wa* today. Tamaki Koshiro says:

Wa can be seen as a basic spirit regulating the way of life in a community. This spirit permeates our families, and our workplaces, not to mention our villages, cities, states, and today, the whole world. Needless to say, it is important to maintain *wa* in each of these communities. Today, maintaining world peace has become a basic condition for the survival of human beings. This fact reminds me that the spirit of *wa* advocated by Prince Shotoku has never been so relevant to our world as today.⁴

This quotation exemplifies the prevailing sense of *wa*'s centrality among Japanese people today. Some even insist that this spirit is part of the Japanese genetic heritage. Below I will argue that, on the contrary, this spirit is an invented tradition and a product of modernity.

The Changing Image of Prince Shotoku In State-Designated History Textbooks

School textbooks published in the Meiji era reveal subtle shifts in the positioning of *wa*. Because the Japanese ruling class was using these textbooks to construct a unified national consciousness, we can assume that they reflected the sanctioned ideas of each period.

The first textbook, *Shogaku Nihon rekishi*, published in 1903, contains the following description:

Prince Shotoku was the child of Emperor Yomei. He was a brilliant child, and as he became older, he made great progress in learning. Shotoku became the crown

³. Takagiwa Hiroo, *Nihonjin ni totte wa to wa nani ka: Shudan ni okeru chitsujo* (Saitama-ken, Niiza-shi: Shogaku Kenkyusha, 1987), 42, 46, 59, 83-84.

⁴. Tamaki Koshiro, "Shotoku taishi to Nihon bukkyo," in Shitennoji Joshi Daigaku, ed., *Shotoku taishi sangyo* (Osaka: Kangakuin, 1979), 65.

prince in the reign of Empress Suiko and dictated all the issues of the government... The prince also believed in Buddhism; he made great attempts to spread the faith with his minister Soga no Umako (?—626), by ordering the construction of a large number of temples and statues of Buddha.... Shotoku also enacted the Seventeen-Article Constitution and thus provided a moral basis to people of all ranks.⁵

Here, although there is no mention of *wa*, the Seventeen-Article Constitution is credited with establishing a common morality. *Jinjo shogaku Nihon rekishi* of 1909 shows the beginning of a greater emphasis on Prince Shotoku as a nationalist figure:

Prince Shotoku was a grandchild of Emperor Kimmie.... The prince adopted some of the strengths of China for our benefit and enacted various new laws. Among them, the Seventeen-Article Constitution is the most famous.⁶

The tendency, reflected in this passage, to emphasize Prince Shotoku's nationalism was retained in later textbooks. The 1920 *Jinjo shogaku kokushi* went one step further. It preserved the sense of previous texts by noting that "the prince enacted the Seventeen-Article Constitution and provided a moral basis to both bureaucrats and citizens," yet it added a new passage: "The prince of the country of the rising sun wrote to the prince of the country of the setting sun. What a noble action!"⁷

The emphasis on Shotoku's nationalism increased following Japan's occupation of Manchuria in 1931 and reflected Japan's growing feeling of superiority over China. The 1934 edition of *Jinjo shogaku kokushi*, for example, contained a description of the Seventeen-Article Constitution—"The prince enacted a moral basis for all people, bureaucrats and commoners alike"—that is almost the same as in previous textbooks. But it lavishly praised the prince's effort to renegotiate Japan's relationship to China: "At that time, China was a powerful nation because of its advanced learning. As such, it tended to be arrogant and dealt with other nations as its colonies. But Prince Shotoku was not in the least afraid of its power."⁸

Even the *Shogaku kokushi* of 1940 did not explicitly link Prince Shotoku to *wa*. Rather, it emphasized his role as a forceful leader: "The prince enacted the Seventeen-Article Constitution and thus instructed his subjects." It also stressed the role of Prince Shotoku as a proponent of nationalism: "He showed how powerful our nation was."⁹ It was only after the onset of the Pacific War (1941-45) and mobilization for total war that Prince Shotoku is depicted as instructing his country in

⁵ *Shogaku Nihon rekishi* (Tokyo: Monbusho, 1903), 17-18.

⁶ *Jinjo shogaku Nihon rekishi* (Tokyo: Monbusho, 1909), 17-18.

⁷ *Jinjo shogaku kokushi* (Tokyo: Monbusho, 1920), 23.

⁸ *Jinjo shogaku kokushi* (Tokyo: Monbusho, 1934), 25-26.

⁹ *Shogaku kokushi* (Tokyo: Monbusho, 1940), 26, 27.

the importance of *wa*. The *Shoto-ka kokushi*, published in 1943, contains the following passage:

Then the prince carefully instructed his subjects by enacting the Seventeen-Article Constitution. In this constitution, the prince gave the strict instructions: "If you are given a decree by the emperor, be sure to follow it"; "All people are subjects of the emperor. Rulers must not torment their people by taking willful actions." He also preached the importance of *wa*... [showing] his wish to bring peace to the people at court who were in conflict.¹⁰

This is the first appearance of *wa* in elementary Japanese history textbooks. The textbook also described Prince Shotoku not as the founder of Japanese Buddhism but as an advocate of Shinto: "The prince ardently worshiped the gods [*kami*], following the example of the emperor.... At that time some people tended to slight the worship of the gods in favor of Buddhism, which came from abroad The prince examined Buddhism thoroughly and in promoting it, adjusted it to the special characteristics of our country."

Surprisingly *wa*, which first appeared in 1943, survived in postwar textbooks. The last state textbook published in 1946, *Kuni no ayumi* contained the following description of Prince Shotoku:

Things had changed inside and outside the country. Seeing this, the prince thought of a way to improve the system of inherited offices, which emphasized family rank. He ordered the ranks so as to promote able people. Then the prince enacted the Seventeen-Article Constitution and preached its precepts to the officials. The Constitution began by teaching the importance of *wa*, which contained the message that people at Court should cooperate with one another in harmony. Further, the Constitution elaborated the moral principles of politics that men in power should not impose taxes arbitrarily on people; they should listen to the people and deal fairly in political matters; they should not decide important issues by themselves, but by consulting many people.¹¹

These two state history textbooks, published in 1943 and 1946, both introduced *wa*—but their connotations differed considerably. The first stressed the importance of national integration under the emperor; the second conveyed a message of harmonious cooperation in re-creating Japan as a peaceful nation.

The Historical Transformation of the Image of Prince Shotoku

At most, textbooks provide signposts indicating shifts in the ideological terrain. We cannot conclude that the collectivist spirit of *wa* is a modern invention simply on the basis of elementary history textbooks. Therefore, I will trace the broader

¹⁰. *Shoto-ka kokushi* (Tokyo: Monbusho, 1943), 31.

¹¹. *Kuni no ayumi* (Tokyo: Monbusho, 1946), 6-7.

historical development of the image of Prince Shotoku and the spirit of *wa* in the Seventeen-Article Constitution. Here too we will find that the nexus between the prince and the spirit of *wa* is most distinct in the modern period.¹²

In the Nara period, the earliest "history" of Japan, *Nihon shoki* (720), described Prince Shotoku as a saint. During this period, the image of the prince changed from a worshiper of Buddha to an object of religious worship himself. *Jogu kotaishi bosatsuden* (754) described the prince as a reincarnation of the Chinese prelate Nangaku Eshi, who succeeded the founder of Tendai Buddhism.¹³ Another text, *Shichidai ki*, written in 771, introduced the theory that the prince was an incarnation of Buddha, who had transformed himself for the seventh time to become Prince Shotoku.

In the Heian period, various books described the prince as a savior, the reincarnation of Kuze Kannon.¹⁴ In Kamakura, after the Mongolian invasions of 1274 and 1281, veneration of the prince stressed his role as a prophet. Taishiko, a popular cult devoted to worshiping the prince, developed at this time among carpenters, plasterers, and stone craftsmen. Taishiko became quite active in the Edo period. Yet in the Edo period there was a countertrend, as some scholars severely criticized the prince for introducing Buddhism into Japan and accused him of being a disloyal minister. For instance, Kumazawa Banzan (1619-91), a Confucian and Shinto scholar, claimed that Prince Shotoku had assassinated the Emperor Sujun (?-592), even though Shotoku's kinsman, Soga no Umako, had done the deed. On the same grounds, the Confucian scholar Nakai Riken (1732-1817) even refused to enter Shitennoji temple, claiming that he would be defiled by doing so. Hayashi Razan (1583-1657), advisor to Tokugawa Ieyasu and chief exponent of the Shushi (Chu Hsi) school of Neo-Confucianism, and Hirata Atsutane (1776-1843), a leading *kokugaku* (nativism) scholar, also asserted that the prince had assassinated Emperor Sujun. Further, a critique added by the Mito School editors of *Dai Nihon shi*¹⁵ described the prince as follows:

The prince said, "Even gods did not dare to violate the ways preached by Buddha." This statement denigrated the worship of the gods. Emperor Yomei fervently worshiped Buddha. Before that time, no prince had worshiped Buddha, but the prince recommended such a practice to the emperor. This action destroyed our national religion.... The prince was more interested in Buddhism than in laws. Therefore, he

¹². Sources cited in the following discussion are drawn primarily from Shotoku Taishi Hosankai, ed., *Shotoku taishi zenshu* (Tokyo: Ryuginsha, 1942-44). Hereafter, *Zenshu*.

¹³. *Zenshu* 3:50.

¹⁴. For example, Sugawara Michizane and Fujiwara Kanesuke, *Shotoku taishi denryaku* (917); Mi-namoto no Tamenori, *Sanpo eshi* (984); and Yoshishige no Tatsutane, *Nihon ojo gokuraku ki* (ca. 986).

¹⁵. The Mito School was a school of nativist historical studies centered in Mito-han. It was known for its chauvinism, emperor-centered historiography, and hostility toward foreign culture. The writing of *Dai Nihon shi*, which was completed in 1715, was initiated by Tokugawa Mitsukuni, the second daimyo of Mito-han, in the mid-seventeenth century.

worked to enthrone an empress who was easy to control, and he spoke boldly. As a result, Buddhism's power came to rival that of the emperor; the rituals of the court included Buddhist services. This was what the prince and Umako wanted.

In this way nationalist scholars severely condemned Prince Shotoku for disrupting the basic structure of the nation by introducing Buddhism. In the period leading up to the Meiji Restoration (1868), when imperial sentiment reached a feverish pitch, Shitennoji became the site of violent protests, including suicides and an incendiary attack that burned twelve buildings on its grounds.

Ironically, Prince Shotoku's image at the end of the Edo period was deeply divided. Although worshiped by artisans, he was despised by nationalist intellectuals. How then, in the modern era, did Prince Shotoku become a paragon of virtue and an icon of *wa*, the essence of the Japanese spirit of harmony, in spite of the criticism of learned scholars in the Edo period? How was their criticism defused? How was his image recast and made compatible with state Shinto and the modern imperial tradition?

Sonoda Muneemi's *Shotoku taishi*, the first modern study of Prince Shotoku, appeared in 1893. Yet interest in Shotoku increased dramatically only after 1903, the 1,300th anniversary of the promulgation of the Seventeen-Article Constitution. Kume Kunitake, a Tokyo University professor of history expelled in 1891 for declaring that Shinto was no more than a folk religion, published *Shotoku taishi jitsuroku*—"a true record of Prince Shotoku"—in that year. The number of works published on Prince Shotoku reached a peak in the years between 1903 and 1921, the 1,300th anniversary of the prince's death.

Kume Kunitake gave a relatively factual account of Shotoku's life, but by 1921 the image of the prince had begun to take on a distinctly nationalist coloring. Previously, the prince had been seen as the introducer of Buddhism in Japan—the benevolent founder of Buddhism, as it were—or as a hero endowed with mystical power. From this point on, however, his image as an enlightened and forceful statesman was emphasized. Behind this new image stood the social turbulence that followed the Russo-Japanese War of 1904-5, which extended into the 1920s. The new image of the prince responded to the rise of nationalism in Japan.

According to Hanayama Shinsho's *Shotoku taishi to Nihon bunka*, it is possible to trace the following trajectory:

Especially in 1903, the 1,300th year since the publication of Prince Shotoku's Seventeen-Article Constitution, and in 1921, the 1,300th anniversary of his death,... enthusiasm for the prince rose suddenly throughout the society. It was not necessarily a coincidence that one of these years was just before the Russo-Japanese War, when our national consciousness was most intense, and the other was a time when our nationalism was at its zenith because of the enormous victory in World War I. Around 1904-5 and around 1921, lectures and Buddhist meetings in praise of Prince Shotoku became frequent. At the same time, a number of excellent books were written by scholars and people in all fields: in Japanese history, law, Buddhism, Shinto, arts, crafts, and architecture. The true value of the prince became increasingly appreciated.

In 1921 the prince was depicted as a mixture of cultural promoter, patron of Buddhist art, Buddhist thinker, poet, and politician. But the image of Prince Shotoku as "the prince of the land of the rising sun" gradually acquired new salience, as did his relationship to the imperial tradition. Article 3 of the Seventeen-Article Constitution ("If you receive a decree from the emperor, be sure to follow it") was emphasized during this period because of its advocacy of unconditional obedience to the emperor's will. Significantly, Article 1, which espoused the principle of *wa*, was of comparatively little importance at this time.

With the approach of war, this patriotic image of Prince Shotoku was gradually strengthened to emphasize his embodiment of the national spirit. Okawa Shumei (1886-1957), a right-wing politician who lent support to the Incident of May 15, 1932 and supported Japanese expansionism in Manchuria, wrote the following in *Nihon nisenroppyaku-nen shi* (1941), a book commemorating the mythical 2,600th anniversary of the imperial state:

Prince Shotoku laid down decisive principles for solving the national problems of his turbulent age. The prince proposed Shinto as the basic principle in politics, Confucianism to improve the moral life of his nation, and Buddhism to regulate its religious life. Thus the prince relied on a spirit of unity, which sought to embrace the new without losing the old, and in so doing, adopted the principles of the Asian civilization appropriate to our national life, which came to our shore one after another. In this way he opened the door to a new age.¹⁶

As this passage demonstrates, Prince Shotoku was now described as the synthesizer of three religions and moral traditions of religion, with Shinto at the core, surrounded by Confucianism and Buddhism. Prince Shotoku was said to have created the Japanese spirit by assimilating Confucianism and Buddhism to indigenous Shinto at a time when the concepts of state and national consciousness needed support. In this way, the prince's historic role of introducing Buddhism to Japan was recast in terms of support for state Shinto and the worship of the emperor. In 1940 Hanayama Shinsho expressed his enthusiasm for the prince:

Recently, our country has withdrawn from the League of the Nations. As the Japanese spirit increasingly came to be emphasized, voices were raised for the third time in memory and praise of the prince. In fact, almost every day we find excellent papers and books that have been published to extol the great works of the prince.

The evolution of the image of Prince Shotoku from early Meiji to the end of World War II can be divided into three periods. As I have mentioned, the first wave of the Shotoku boom began in 1903, the 1,300th anniversary of the publication of the Seventeen-Article Constitution. The image presented during this period was of Shotoku as an enlightened and forceful cultural reformer. However, in 1921, the 1,300th anniversary of his death, the image of the prince as a politician

¹⁶. Okawa Shumei, *Nihon nisenroppyakunen shi* (Tokyo, 1941), 15-16.

came to be stressed. The latter half of the 1930s saw a third wave, in which the prince came to be associated with both *wa* and worship of the imperial family.

As Hanayama Shinsho has stated, one of the central ideas relating to the prince in the latter half of the 1930s was the worship of *kami*, Japan's national gods. The prince did in fact discuss worship of the "three treasures,"¹⁷ but without specific reference to the worship of *kami*. Nevertheless, sympathetic commentators simply attributed *kami* worship to him on the assumption that it was something which, because it had been taken for granted, did not require comment; indeed, it followed logically from the assumed centrality of Shinto. Commentators also found ways to explain away his silence on the subject of the emperor. And scholars in the 1930s argued, with regard to his supreme loyalty to the emperor, that the prince had to promote Soga no Umako, who assassinated Emperor Sujun, simply because the Soga clan was too powerful to be ignored. He had no choice. These scholars claimed, however, that in practice Prince Shotoku resisted the Soga clan and made tremendous efforts to conduct politics under the emperor. Accordingly his loyalty to the imperial system was firm.

Commentators also found reason to praise Prince Shotoku in his role as a nationalist. One letter addressed by the prince to the Sui dynasty court bore the subscription "From the Son of Heaven of the Land of the Rising Sun to the Son of Heaven of the Land of the Setting Sun."¹⁸ Scholars used this phrase to argue that the prince worked to establish equal foreign relations, advocated nationalism (both of the state and of the people), and promoted the power of the nation. Such viewpoints dominated the image of the prince as a representative of Japanese culture and national spirit.

***Wa* and Interpretation of the Seventeen-Article Constitution**

Like the image of Prince Shotoku, the spirit of *wa* advocated in Article I of the Seventeen-Article Constitution was transformed during the modern period. I will analyze the shifting interpretations of Prince Shotoku's constitution with special reference to *wa*. We will see that this principle came to the fore (with various interpretations) only during the first four decades of this century.

Until the Meiji Restoration, scholars interpreted the Constitution as "a basic moral code for the princes who have reached enlightenment." Many seized on the word *wa* in the passage from the Confucian *Analects* that reads, "To practice *rei* (social decorum) is to promote *wa*," or they simply interpreted it as peace of mind. We find such passages as "*Rei* is the form, *wa* is the practice"; and "*Wa* is the fusion of

¹⁷. The "three treasures" refer to Buddha, Dharma, and Sangha—the Buddha, the Law, and the Priesthood.

¹⁸. Quoted in Ryusaku Tsunoda, ed., *Sources of Japanese Tradition* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1958), 39.

two things into one idea. When good and evil are separate, we do not achieve *wa*"; and "*Kokoro* [heart/mind] is the form; *wa* is the practice." I have not found a single discussion of *wa* in relation to the Seventeen-Article Constitution that posited that Article x advocated *wa* as the basic idea of the Constitution itself. Rather, they regarded *wa* as merely one element within the Constitution as a whole.

A gradual change appeared after the Meiji Restoration. In 1893 Ariga Nagao's *Shotoku taishi jushichijo no kenpo* discussed *wa* as "the basic principle for governing a nation and achieving peace for its people."¹⁹ A little later, in 1916, Kuroita Katsumi's *Shotoku taishi no jushichijo no kenpo ni tsuite* stressed the theme of "peace among the ruling class and harmony among the ruled."²⁰ Here, as in Okada Masayuki's 1917 work, *Kenpo jushichijo ni tsuite*, *wa* was constructed as part of a hierarchical relationship rather than an equal and harmonious one.²¹

It is worth noting that while most commentators emphasized the achievement of order and harmony in a vertical and hierarchical relationship, they did not identify *wa* as Prince Shotoku's basic principle. Rather, they stressed Article 3, which advocated loyalty to the emperor, as the central theme of the Constitution. This trend continued through the Taisho period. In the 1930s, however, as war approached, the concept of *wa* and its place in the Constitution began to change. In this time of national emergency, *wa* suddenly began to be represented as the basis of national consciousness. It took on the ideological function of state integration.

According to Suzuki Masayuki of Kobe University, the rise of nationalism and the development of party politics in the Taisho period produced the "organ theory of the emperor."²² This new ideology balanced party politics and monarchism. The image began to alter in the early Showa period, however. At a time when the conflicts among the world's superpowers were beginning to take on special importance, it did not seem to be able to portray Japan's special features that could match those of the United States and Europe. A sense of crisis prevailed in the latter half of the 1920s and the ensuing Great Depression. In early Showa, for instance, the Christian educator Nitobe Inazo stated: "Japan has nothing to be proud of except its national polity [*kokutai*]." The notion of "national polity" was paralleled by an increasing emphasis on the concept of *wa*. The idea became firmly established that the Japanese spirit, the emperor system, and *wa* constituted unique traditions that could stand against those of the United States

¹⁹. *Zenshu* 1:440.

²⁰. *Zenshu* 1:451.

²¹. *Zenshu* 1:467.

²². Suzuki Masayuki, *Kindai tennosei no shihai chitsujo* (Tokyo: Azekura Shobo, 1986). The "organ theory of the emperor" was advocated by Minobe Tatsukichi in 1912. Minobe argued that, although the emperor represented the supreme origin of government, he was also an organ of the state with governmental functions based on the Japanese Constitution. See Frank C. Miller, *Minobe Tatsukichi, Interpreter of Constitutionalism in Japan* (Berkeley and Los Angeles: University of California Press, 1965).

and Europe. An increasing emphasis on spiritual mobilization in the 1930S gave the idea of *wa* a new centrality. The most famous example is found in *Kokutai no hongi* (1937), edited by the Educational Bureau of the Ministry of Education:

When we trace the development and history of our country, we never fail to find *wa*. *Wa* was born of great works done by our country; its spirit resides not only in the power to form history but also in the government of everyday life.²³ . . . In our country, we have observed a close unity between the emperor and the people. We have embodied beauty in such ideas as "all people united with the emperor as their leader," and in the assiduous cooperation by successive generations to maintain our nation. The sacred virtue of the emperor and the fidelity of his subjects have fused to create a beautiful harmony.²⁴

Ono Seiichiro's *Kenpo jushichijo ni okeru kokka to rinri* (1938) posits Prince Shotoku's constitution not as a mere guide to everyday life but as "a theory for governing the nation"²⁵ and as "the ethical basis of the state." It was seen as "maintaining existing hierarchical distinctions, making them useful for affairs of state."²⁶ In this reading, the ethic of *wa* presupposed a hierarchical order in society and asserted the unity of the nation on this basis. This was an organic conception: *wa* was capable of maintaining harmony in a whole made up of distinctive and separate parts; it was hierarchical and holistic:

Wa involves morals for individuals. Moreover, it is a supreme ethic for the community of a state. It is a manifestation of the ethical order on which the state of Japan should rely. What is *wa*? It is not merely peace achieved on the surface. It is inner and spiritual harmony and peace. This ideal brings about a unity of communal spirit by maintaining not only hierarchical distinctions but also the essential equality of an ethical order. It should be the ethic that will bring forth continuity, integration, and unity in the state Truly, the ethic of *wa*, or the ethic of "all people, one mind" is the supreme essence of our state.²⁷

Epilogue: *Wa* and Prince Shotoku in Postwar History

This fascination with *wa* and the Seventeen-Article Constitution survived even in the postwar period. Questionnaires asking about people's favorite figures in

²³ . Japan Ministry of Education, *Kokutai no hongi: Cardinal Principles of the National Entity of Japan*; trans. John Owen Gauntlett; ed. with an introduction by Robert King Hall (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Press, 1949), 50

²⁴ . Ibid., 57-58.

²⁵ . *Zenshu* 1:609

²⁶ . *Zenshu* 1:623.

²⁷ . *Zenshu* 1:622. As an additional example, I recently discovered an interesting item in a secondhand bookshop. It was a box containing a volume of the Seventeen-Article Constitution, distributed as a souvenir of the opening of the Research Center for National Spiritual Culture in 1935. The Constitution had become such a part of the center's propaganda in the 1930S that it was distributed as a souvenir.

Japanese history today usually discover that Prince Shotoku or Minamoto no Yoshitsune is in first place. Yoshitsune's popularity is understandable, but how is it that Prince Shotoku's reputation, and his association with the spirit of *wa*, survive to this day?

We should recall that Prince Shotoku's renown is of relatively recent origin. According to Takeda Sawako's *Shinko no oken Shotoku taishi*, when the government considered in 1887 whose image would grace its currency the prince was excluded from the final list of historical figures. Only in 1930, the period when the prince became the icon of nationalist consciousness, was he included. After the Pacific War, the prince appeared on ¥1,000, ¥5,000, and ¥10,000 notes. The American occupation authorities had banned the publication of Shinto images and debated banning Prince Shotoku's as well because he had been a patriotic symbol during the war. However, the director of the Bank of Japan managed to persuade the Americans that the prince was a pacifist, for the prince taught that "it is noble to achieve *wa*; make it a principle not to have conflicts."

In the postwar period, Prince Shotoku survived as a symbol of *wa*, the principle that teaches harmonious cooperation. This *wa* signifies equality, as we have seen in the example of state textbooks. Today the image of the prince and the significance of *wa* are still being debated.

In sum, Prince Shotoku and the spirit of *wa* became a newly created tradition in a time of national crisis—the turbulent decade of the 1930S and the Pacific War. It performed an ideological function by addressing the need for unification. The artificiality of this invention is pointed up by its variability: not only was Prince Shotoku's reputation revised profoundly during Japan's modern period, but both the definition of *wa* and its place in the Constitution fluctuated wildly, depending on the ideological needs of the moment.